



American soldiers wade ashore from a landing craft during the invasion of Normandy on June 6. The landings began the liberation of Occupied France.

**150,000** THE NUMBER OF **ALLIED TROOPS** THAT LANDED ON THE **NORMANDY BEACHES**

**9,000** THE NUMBER OF **ALLIED CASUALTIES** DURING THE LANDINGS

**IN EARLY 1944 THERE WAS HEAVY FIGHTING IN ITALY** as German troops blocked the Allied advance on Rome. In January, Allied seaborne landings at **Anzio**, behind the Germans' defensive Gustav Line, failed to break the deadlock. In February, Allied commanders decided to bomb the medieval abbey at Monte Cassino, a key point in the Gustav Line, but this much-criticized act of desecration was also ineffectual. **Monte Cassino eventually fell to the Polish infantry** in May, allowing Rome to be liberated the following month.

In the spring, British Indian troops withstood a Japanese attempt to invade northeast India from Burma. The **Japanese offensive** was so successfully repulsed that Allied forces were able to mount their own offensive to retake much of Burma later in the year. With the Quit India

movement (see 1942) also suppressed, the British had reasserted their authority over the subcontinent.

Meanwhile, Allied preparations for an **invasion of Occupied France** turned southern England into an armed camp. Operation **Overlord**, was commanded by General Dwight D. Eisenhower (1890–1969). The Allies chose Normandy as the target for their invasion. Postponed because of bad weather, the **Normandy landings** took place on June 6, referred to as **D-Day**.

During the night, 18,000 airborne troops landed by parachute or glider behind the German coastal defenses. At dawn, a fleet of 5,000 ships carrying around 130,000

#### Burma Star

*This military medal was awarded to British and Commonwealth soldiers for service in the Burma campaign between 1941 and 1945.*



soldiers arrived offshore.

It was the **largest amphibious operation in history**. Three of the five landing beaches, codenamed **Sword**, **Juno**, and **Utah**, were taken with relative ease by British, Canadian, and US troops, but the British at **Gold**

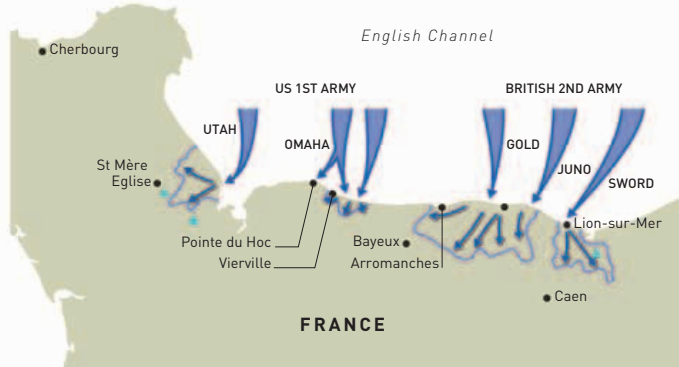
beach and especially the Americans at **Omaha** beach suffered substantial losses before securing ground.

Two ingenious innovations, the **Mulberry floating harbor** and the Pluto undersea oil pipeline, allowed supplies to reach Allied forces once ashore. A grueling struggle ensued to break out of Normandy, and German resistance was not overcome until August.

Meanwhile, **Adolf Hitler** (1889–1945) survived an **assassination attempt**. A plot was mounted by patriotic German officers and officials to overthrow the Führer and seek peace with the Western allies. On July 20, Colonel Claus Schenk von Stauffenberg (1907–1944) carried a bomb in his briefcase to a meeting at Hitler's headquarters at Rastenburg, East Prussia. He placed the bomb under a table at which Hitler was sitting. It

exploded, devastating the room and killing four people, but the **dictator survived unscathed**. Stauffenberg and some of the other leading conspirators were shot by firing squad; thousands more were arrested and tortured, many suffering lingering deaths. Field Marshal Erwin Rommel (1891–1944) was also implicated in the plot, but he was permitted to commit suicide.

The breakout of Allied forces from Normandy in August (see p.389) led rapidly to the **liberation of Paris**. After French Resistance fighters began an uprising in the city on August 19, General Charles de Gaulle's Free French forces, fighting as part of Eisenhower's Allied armies, raced for Paris. A column of French tanks reached central Paris on August 25.



#### D-Day Landings

*The Allies landed on five Normandy beaches—Sword, Juno, Gold, Utah, and Omaha. Allied troops also parachuted in behind enemy lines.*

#### KEY

- Allied landing/advance
- Allied parachute landing
- Allied front line June 7, 1944

